

Cemeteries of New Orleans

A Guide



J. Arthur Guidry



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Origins

With their elaborate monuments and mausoleums, the historic cemeteries of New Orleans have often been called Cities of the Dead. Formed by both necessity and tradition, these ornate necropoli offer visitors a glimpse into the unique and vibrant history of the Crescent City.

From the city's earliest days, New Orleanians have faced a unique problem: burying their dead. Since

New Orleans lies well below sea level, below-ground burials are, at best, unwise, and at worst, impossible. Records indicate that early residents discovered this fact very quickly. Their first attempts at underground interments were largely unsuccessful, despite the use of large stones to try to weight the coffins. This strategy was no match for the rising waters, and one storm was all it took to bring the deceased back to the surface.

In contrast, above-ground burials had long been a common practice in eighteenth-century France and Spain. As many of our forebears had roots in these countries, there was little, if any, leap of faith to quickly adopt this practice. Those with means commissioned imposing tombs adorned with sculptural art and engraved likenesses of their loved ones, while others found their final repose in far more humble settings.

New Orleans Tombs

In New Orleans, historical tombs generally fall into one of four types: family tombs, society tombs, wall vaults, and coping graves. Each of these types offers a unique solution to the geological situation at hand, allowing the deceased to remain undisturbed in perpetuity.

Family tombs were, as their name suggests, created for the exclusive use of one family. They contain a small number of chambers—usually no more than three—and are able to house the remains of several generations.

For those without the ability to finance a family tomb, society tombs became popular as a way to bury the dues-paying members of an organization—for example, the New Orleans Italian Mutual Benevolent Society. Much larger than family tombs, society tombs have room for as many as a dozen vaults. Over time, they can support hundreds of burials.

Wall vaults have always been one of the most economical burial options. These brick structures line many historic New Orleans cemeteries, with long rows of graves contained within the same wall. Some of these structures are also known as *oven vaults* due to the shape of the opening, which resembles an old-fashioned kiln.

And finally, for those who wished to receive a below-ground burial, coping graves were created. Following the lessons learned from the settlers' unsuccessful struggles with the water table, these graves seal off the coffin with stone walls. Typically, the grave extends several feet above ground and is covered in gravel. In many cemeteries, coping graves are surrounded by cast iron fencing.



Wall vaults in a New Orleans cemetery.

A Year and a Day

Due to the way the tombs are affected by the sweltering climate of New Orleans, structures often provide a far larger number of burials than the number of vaults suggests. Sealed off from

ventilation and surrounded by brick insulation, the tombs trap heat to become slow-burning cremation chambers that can accommodate multiple bodies over time. Similar to a car with closed doors and windows, the interior temperature of a vault will typically rise to twice the temperature of the outside air, no matter the season. For example, if the temperature outside on a summer day is 92 degrees, inside the vault the temperature would reach at least 184 degrees, if not much greater.

Since the remains in these tombs are cremated naturally, many cemeteries follow the "year and a day rule." This tradition allows the remaining bones to be eventually relocated to a lower chamber called a *caveau*, where the remains of several individuals rest together. Once the upper chamber is cleared, a new body may be interred in the vault.

Our Most Historic Necropoli

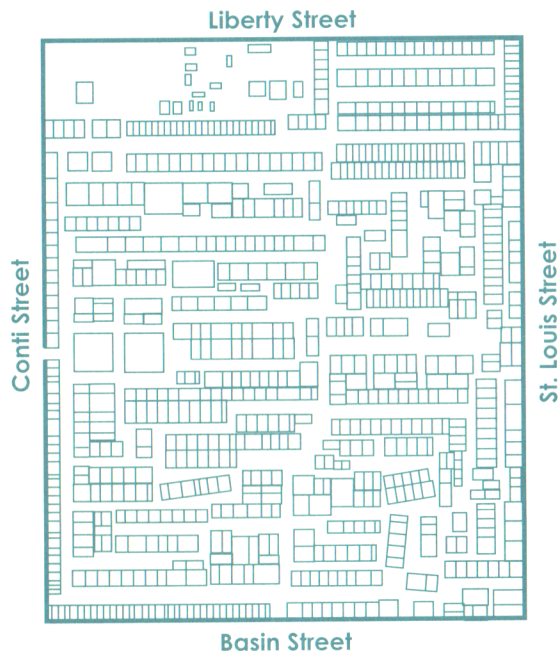
Of all the historic cemeteries in New Orleans, the three oldest are St. Louis Cemetery No. 1 and St.

Louis Cemetery No. 2, located near the French Quarter, and Lafayette Cemetery No. 1, located in the Garden District.

Known to locals and visitors alike, St. Louis Cemetery No. 1 is the oldest currently-existing cemetery in New Orleans. Founded in 1789, it was

created to replace the now-defunct Cimetière St. Pierre after a 1788 fire required officials to re-plan much of the city.

Over the years, thousands of New Orleans residents have found their final resting place in this one square block. Famous individuals buried in St. Louis Cemetery No. 1 include the "Voodoo Queen" Marie Laveau, whose grave has become a major tourist attraction; New Orleans' first mayor, Étienne de Boré; and architect Benjamin Latrobe, who popularized the Greek Revival style in New Orleans and beyond.



St. Louis Cemetery No. 2 is located three blocks away from its counterpart. Founded in 1823, the second St. Louis was designed to be significantly larger than the first, mostly due to its location on what was once the outskirts of the city. Though it was damaged during Hurricane Katrina, recent restorations have been successful in preserving some of the historic structures. Famous burials include musicians Danny Barker and Ernie K. Doe, as well as Catholic nun and humanitarian Mother Henriette DeLille.

Lafayette Cemetery No. 1 was founded in what was then called the city of Lafayette, and is now the home of New Orleans' Garden District. Opened in 1833, it was the first planned cemetery in the city, a fact made clear by its clearly marked four quadrants. These quadrants intersect at a cross-shaped area designed for funeral processions. Notable burials include members of the Jefferson Fire Company Number 22, who are interred together in a society tomb.

About the Author



J. Arthur Guidry is a New Orleans-based historian, podcaster, and walking tour guide. A seventh-generation resident of the Crescent City, it is his hope that this guide will inspire and edify both tourists and locals alike.



Crescent City Restoration Fund
New Orleans, Louisiana